and drew up his horsemen in the centre. He sent his son Afzal Khan to command one wing crowning the heights to the left, while the Mir Wali took the high ground on the opposite side of the valley.[92] But, as the Afghans were still learning to their cost, it was always an error to concentrate their troops in a plain when the British were armed with modern cannon. The British horse artillery was able to mow down the charging Afghan cavalry long before they were able to reach the guns:

> Frenzied and foaming, the army of Firang
> Did not delay the fight for a moment
>
> All at once the entire horde
> Attacked like a pestilential wind
>
> With their cannonballs and gunfire
> They made the very earth and heavens tremble
>
> The Firangis appeared in those flames
> As would the demons of hellfire.

Seeing the way the battle was going, and with a severe wound on his thigh, Dost Mohammad withdrew, leaving a hundred dead on the battlefield, but saving most of his forces to fight another day. He remained, however, undaunted and instead of retreating he headed on by goatpaths and dry riverbeds over the mountains towards Kabul, intent on meeting up with the Tajik insurgents in Kohistan.

This was both a brave and a risky strategy. Macnaghten had sent Burnes with ‘Fighting Bob’ Sale and two regiments to occupy the district headquarters at Charikar, and these troops were now blocking the main road between the Amir and the Kohistan rebels. Moreover, Dost Mohammad had many Kohistani enemies. Only a year previously the Kohistanis had risen against him as the British advanced on Kabul. But the Amir gambled that it was his best hope, and that a mutual hatred of the new Kafir government would for the moment trump earlier enmities. He sent emissaries ahead to the Tajik chiefs, and delegated his ally, the Safi Mir of Tagab, to persuade the sheikhs and mirs of Kohistan and Ghurband to combine under his leadership. He was therefore greatly relieved when his overtures received an immediate reply. Ghulam Kohistani, the author of the *Jangnama*, was